Research Workshop Spring 2026

“Writing”

Part 2: RAP

CEMFI

Reader's Question: What's Your Contribution

- Answer to this question is the main message for a research paper
- The main message is a claim
- *Evidence to support your contribution:*
  - *3 questions: what, how, and why you did your analysis*
  - *Findings + why they matter (for society)*
- *Research climate*
  - *Currently reliable methods*
  - *Open questions in the lit – compare to other studies*

Method: 3 Layers

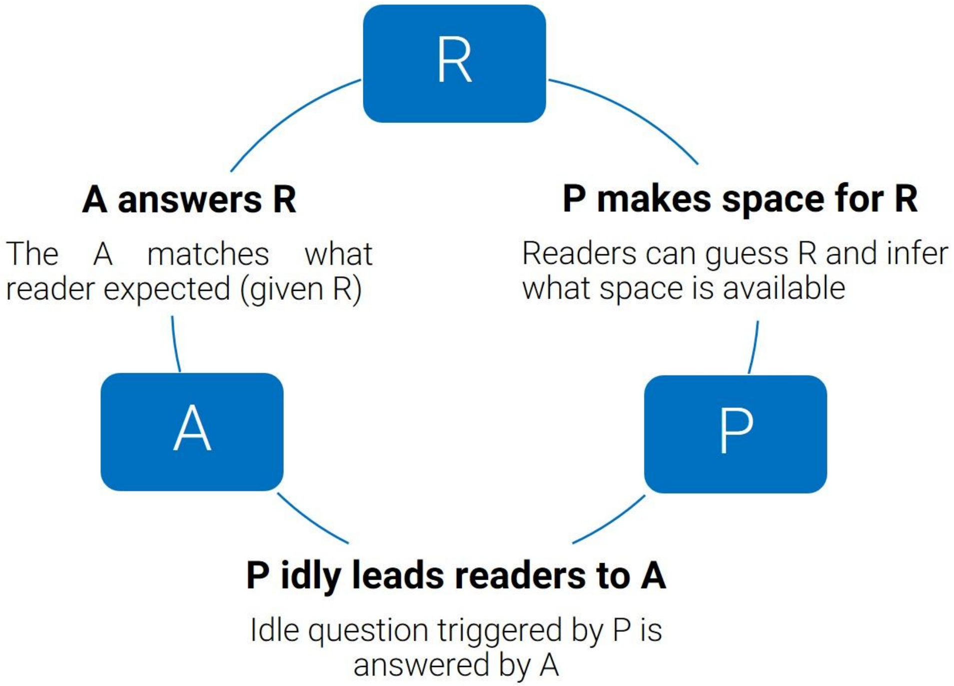
- **Positioning:** articulate a concise argument about what knowledge the paper contributes

- **Outline:** build an outline to support this argument

- **Paragraphs:** linking the points of the outline

Layer 1: the R.A.P Method

- **R**. = research question, articulated to be meaningful to readers
- **A.** = answer that the paper delivers
- **P.** = positioning of the paper, i.e. which gap in the literature it fills



Research Question (R)

- *Meaningful to readers*
  - *Too broad – unrealistic expectations*
  - *Too narrow – miss relevance*

- *Feedback is key*
  - *Keep track of your R (different versions)*
  - *Who is your primary/secondary audience?*
  - *What expectations does R induce?*
    - *The scope of the paper and its contribution*
    - *The answer*

Answer (A)

- *Write down the main findings*
  - *First descriptively*
  - *Then your interpretation*

- *Articulate a summary statement*
  - *Abstract from details, but which ones?*
  - *Ask for feedback*

- *Keep a log of A and iterate*

Example 1

- *Finding: I find that applying on R-filter to the Wong-Wolichski process cuts processing times by 20%. In addition, it provides a tighter range of values. The R-filter can also be applied to other Wong-Wolichski type processes.*

- A: Applying an R-filter to Wong-Wolichski **type** sequential processes yields **more precise** estimates, **faster**.

    - A is like a summary statement

Example 2

- *Finding: In settings dominated by nominal pathways, the occurrences of lateral turns is between 20% - 30% more frequent. The mechanism for such turns is unlike the mechanism when nominal pathways do not exist. Specifically, turns are propelled primarily by torson rather than level forces due to the dominant effect of the former in nominal pathways.*

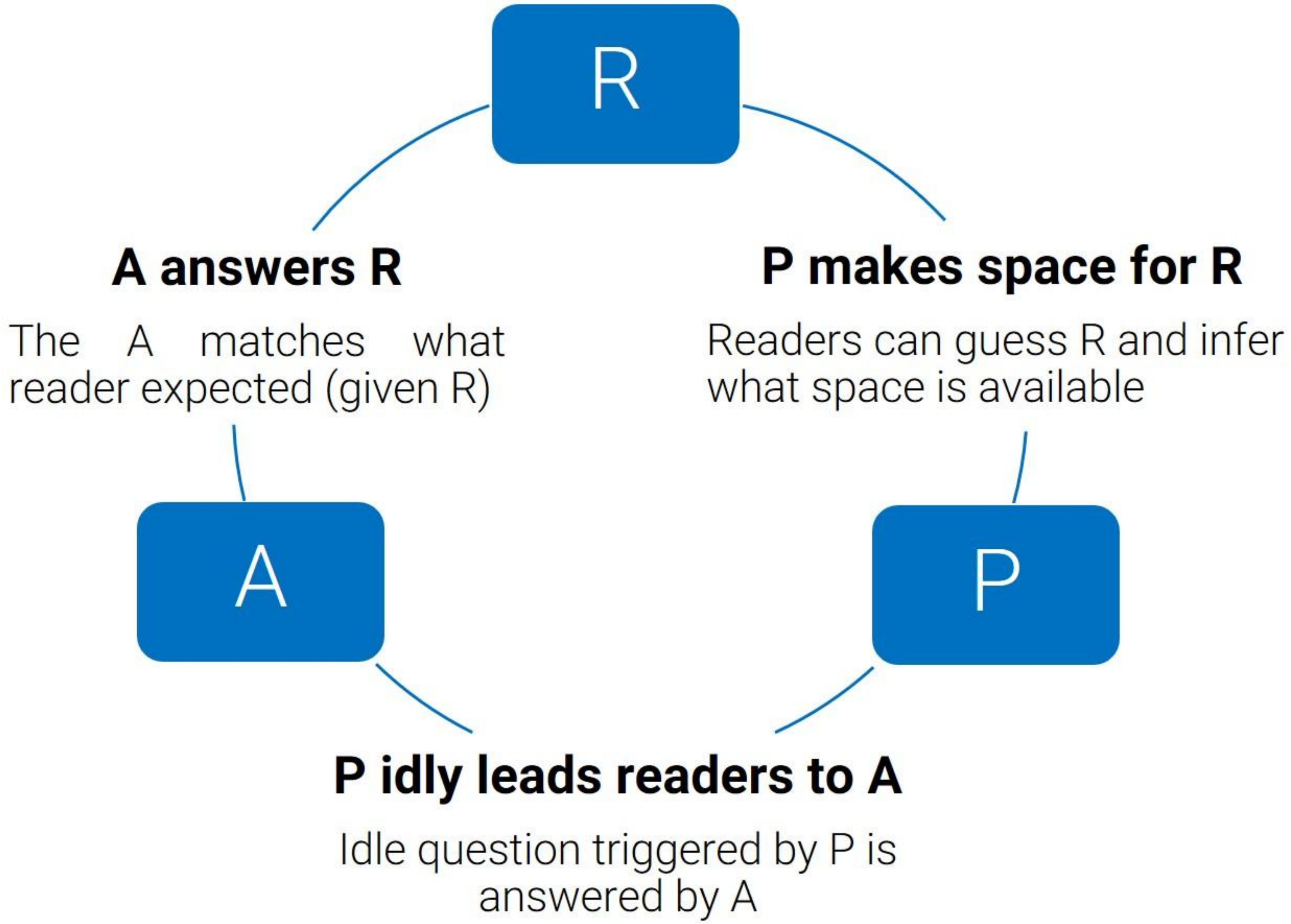
- A: In the presence of nominal pathways, lateral turns occur **more often** **because** torson forces are greater than levet forces.

    - Articulating A is extracting the main message

Positioning - Pushing the Frontier of Knowledge

- Your P should state:
  - A single statement that allows the reader to see a space in the literature, an unanswered question, which R and A will target
  - What's known
  - Important direction to advance towards
  - Then, the readers can decide whether the paper is worth reading.
  - Expectation about your question (R)

Bind Your RAP



Does P Makes Space for R?

P: "The International Development Association is proposing to spend $20M on X hoping it will cause Y, but we do not yet have evidence of a causal relationship between the two ."

- Guess R
- What do you infer about the stock of knowledge prior to this paper?

Does P Idly Lead Readers to A?

P: "The International Development Association is proposing to spend \$20M on X hoping it will cause Y, but we do not yet have evidence of a causal relationship between the two ."

- Do you care about learning A?
- Ask people outside of your field – what idle question is triggered

Does A answer R?

- It's surprising how often the answer is no, maybe because of us trying to be too poetic...
  - *Do CEOs Set Their Own Pay? The Ones Without Principals Do (Bertrand and Mullainathan, 2000)*
  - *Do CEOs Rewarded For Luck? The Ones Without Principals Do (Bertrand and Mullainathan, 2001)*

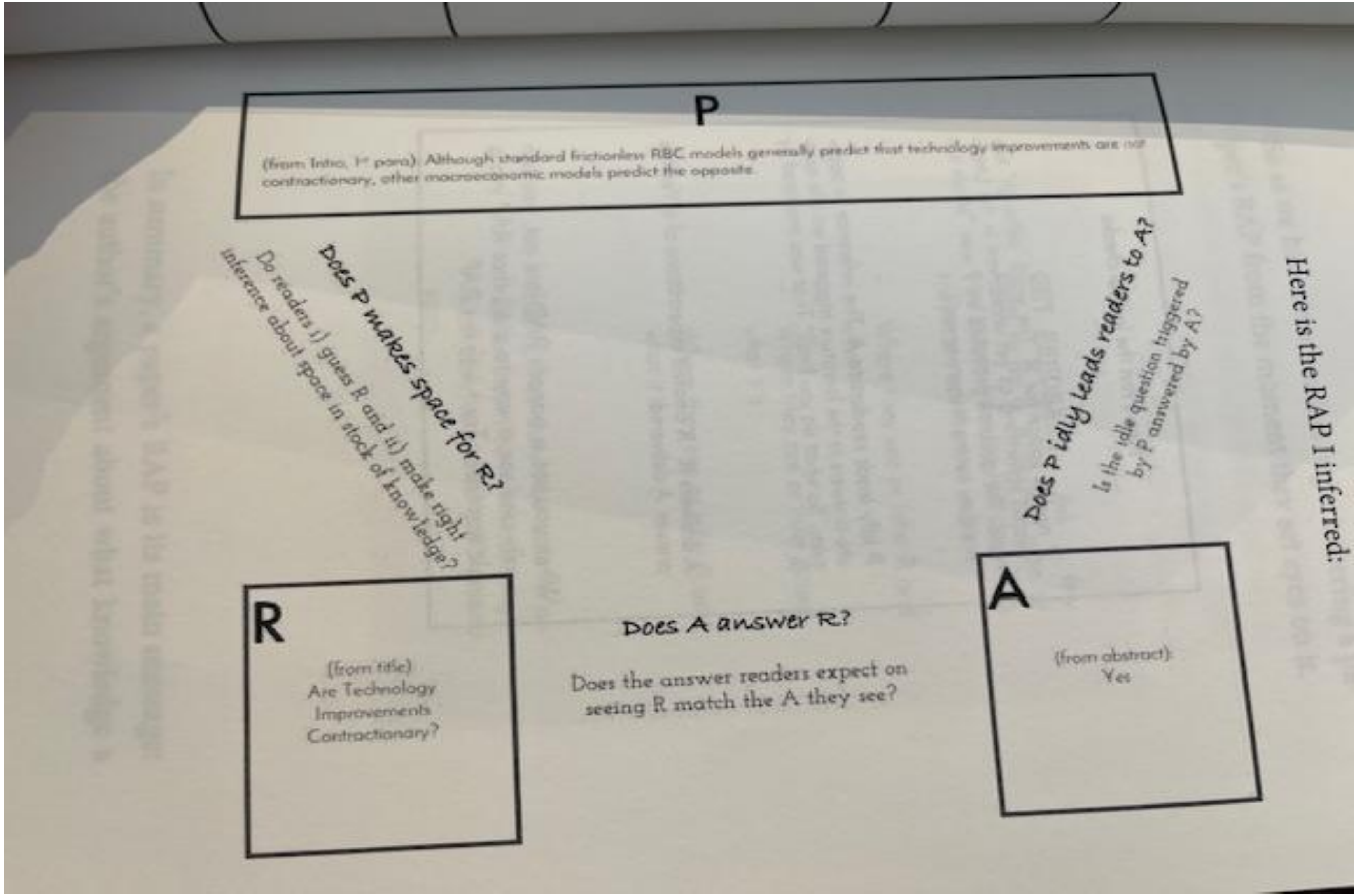
Iterative Process

- R, A, P are closely related, so you can shift ideas across them to see what makes the most interesting combination

- Note: when RAP changes, it will ripple throughout the paper

- Split into pairs (different fields) and evaluate each other's RAP
    - Use the 'RAP Template' document to evaluate it

RAP – Basu et al (2006)



Your own RAP

- Think about your own paper?
- What are R, A, and P?
- Come up with one sentence for each? Tomorrow (email me before tomorrow's class)
- Do they connect?